

RISE OF 'DEVBHOOMI' HIMACHAL

This hill state with a strong economy is showing growth in all avenues like tourism, IT, manufacturing and pharmaceuticals. With its well connected network of roads, telecommunication and immense education opportunities, Himachal is fast emerging as a state to watch.

Himachal Pradesh is a small hill state, which has made its name for spectacular achievements. Known as Devbhoomi and the Apple State of the country, it has forged ahead as the frontrunner in education, health, social services, women empowerment, environment protection, employment generation, macro economy and capital investment. Starting from scratch, Himachal Pradesh has been marching steadily on the path of progress and development. During last 22 months, it has witnessed a meteoric rise in all spheres and has become the fastest moving state in the country.

Achievement Oriented Government

Himachal Pradesh is ranked No 1 State in India by India Today, in terms of its achievements in investment climate, primary education and healthcare. It has also received the Diamond State Award, the highest honour for environment protection. Its developmental plans such as enlargement of green cover will take the state to its next level.

Welfare is its Goal

The Government under the stewardship of its Chief Minister Prof. Prem Kumar Dhumal, is providing the best ever social service to the people. Over 2.52 lakh people who are old, widowed and handicapped are being provided Social Security Pension in the state, which is remarkable.

The emphasis on the welfare and development of under privileged and weaker sections of the society has led to the enhancement of the allocation under the scheduled caste sub-plan from Rs 231 crore in 2007-08 to Rs 668 crore in 2009-10, which comes to one fourth of the State Annual Plan. Dr. B.R. Ambedkar Bhawans are being constructed in every constituency at a cost of Rs. 10 lakh each to provide facilities to the weaker sections for organising social activities.

Empowerment of Women

Himachal Pradesh is the first State in the country which has taken effective steps towards women empowerment. Himachal Pradesh is perhaps the first state in the country to provide 50 per cent reservation in Panchayati Raj Institutions and local bodies to women in the year 2008 and to enlist their active participation in developmental process. The insurance cover under Matri Shakti Bima Yojana has been enhanced from Rs 25,000 to Rs 1 lakh in case of death and from Rs 12,500 to 50,000 in case of loss of one limb to the women beneficiary. This is also applicable in case of death or injury of a spouse.

The World Bank Survey Report has eulogised the efforts of the state in this direction. It says, "Himachal Pradesh has some of the best indicators in terms of gender equality and access to services." This report is based on the implementation of Himalayan Watershed Development Project in the state.

Key Sectors of Development

Proper roads, education and health are the key sectors of development. Special thrust is being given to these segments with a view to improve the quality of life. All villages having a population of more than 500 are likely to be provided with road connectivity this year. The goal is to reach to all the villages with more than 250 heads by the year 2012.

Education is the Keystone of Development

Himachal Pradesh is swiftly moving towards becoming the education hub of the country with prestigious institutions reaching the state. Private sector participation in setting up of educational institutions of excellence is being ensured. The Government plans to set up 16 universities in the state in near future such as Indian Institute of Technology (IIT), Central University, National Institute of Fashion Technology (NIFT), Hydro Power Engineering College.

Health for All

Efforts are afoot to provide better health care facilities to reach the people at their door steps. The state has a network of two medical colleges-cum-hospitals and over 3800 health institutions in the government sector alone. Five medical colleges in private sector

and an ESI medical college-cum-multi-specialty hospital are coming up soon in the state. It has appointed 400 doctors to reinforce its medical strength.

Three Keystones of Development

Agriculture, horticulture and animal husbandry are the mainstay of the people of the state. Providing employment to almost 70 per cent of the working population, highest priority has been given for improving the socio-economic condition of the farmers. An ambitious Rs 353 crore programme known as Pandit Deen Dayal Kisan Bagwan Samridhi Yojna has been launched in the state this year and is being implemented so as to diversify the production of cash crops through poly-houses and providing irrigation facilities by allowing a subsidy of 80 per cent to the farmers for construction of poly-houses and irrigation facilities.

Another ambitious Rs 300 crore 'Doodh Ganga' scheme has been launched with a view to give boost to milk production and create self-employment opportunities in the state. About 1200 self-help groups benefitting 50,000 families will be provided soft loans to adopt animal husbandry for self-employment under this scheme.

Harnessing Energy

Energy conservation measures being taken by Himachal Pradesh have been lauded at the national level. An ambitious Rs. 80 crore 'Atal Biju Bachat Yojna' has been implemented in the state under which compact fluorescent light bulbs have been provided to 16 lakh domestic consumers of the state free of cost. The scheme has not only helped in conserving energy but also in saving the environment from degradation.

Himachal Pradesh has vast hydel potential which comes to about 25 per cent to the country's potential. Out of this, over 6,000 MW has been harnessed and the Government has formulated an ambitious plan for harnessing the remaining potential. The state has identified hydel potential of over 21,000 MW. The Government has set a target to exploit additional 12,000 MW power potential by the year 2012.

Encouraging Tourism

The Government has made efforts to break the seasonal factor. Tourism has been diversified and Himachal is now attracting tourists round-the-year. A 20-year Master Plan is under way for an integrated development of tourism in the state. Besides developing infrastructure to promote tourism in lesser known areas, Home-Stay Scheme has also been launched in the state to provide tourism in rural areas.

Socio-Economic Justice

In its objective of ensuring socio-economic justice to the poor, the Government is implementing various schemes aimed at their speedy uplift. The 2, 98,291 below poverty line families have been given health cover under 'Rashtriya Swasthya Bima Yojna'. The working class in the state is amongst the best paid in the country. The Government of Himachal has always given priority to youth. More than 28,000 employment opportunities have been created in the government sector during last 22 months. About 70 per cent jobs are being ensured in all hydel projects and industrial units to the Himachalis.

Information and Communication Technology (ICT) is a Tool for Good Governance

Himachal Pradesh has charted for itself an e-Governance road map with the conscious decision of ensuring steady and planned movement towards utilisation of information and communication technology for citizen-centric governance. While various centrally-funded schemes for basic infrastructure have been already implemented or are at various stages of implementation, the State Government has taken many initiatives of its own to ensure front-end and back-end computerisation of services.

Himachal was one of the first states to have implemented a State Wide Area Network. Using this connectivity as a backbone, major government services are now web-enabled with a central repository of data for better functioning. E-Samadhan is one such application where every citizen of the state can communicate grievances pertaining to any department right up to the level of Honourable Chief Minister. In Shimla district, 16